

Food and Health (Part - 2)

PROCESS OF GROWING THE FOOD

We all know that our food comes from the fields. The farmers work in the fields and grow food for us. But do you know that the whole process of growing food, takes a long time and needs a lot of effort. Let us discuss the Process of growing food step by step:



Fig: Process of growing food

Ploughing: First of all the field is prepared to grow the food. Ploughing of soil is done so that the soil particles get enough air and become soft too. In earlier days ploughing was done by the traditional plough with the help of animals such as ox.



Fig: Ploughing

But now we have modern machines to plough the fields such as tractors which are attached to the plough making the process easy.

Sowing: After the soil has been made soft the next step is to sow the seeds. Any crop cannot be sown in any field. The crop to be grown depends upon the type of soil.



Fig: Sowing

- A few examples are:

1. Alluvial soil which is rich in nutrients, is used for growing rice and sugarcane. This type of soil is found in North India.
2. Black soil is suitable to grow wheat and cotton. It contains a large amount of clay.
3. Mountain soil which is somewhat acidic in nature is suitable for growing tea and coffee in it.

- The farmers get the seeds either from the seed shops or they use the seeds saved from the last year crops. The seeds come from adult plants to make new.

1. Watering: After the seeds are grown, the next step is to water the seeds which later grow into small plants. The amount of water needed for a crop to grow depends upon the type of crop.



Fig: Watering

- Weeding: Weeding means to remove weeds. Weeds are the unwanted plants which grow with the crops. The weeds use the nutrients and minerals from the soil the way the crop does. So it becomes important to remove them so

that they do not compete with the crop for the nutrients which are important for 'It the crop.



Fig: Weeding

he major ways to get rid of the weeds is by hand picking or these days herbicides are also used.

- Manure: It contributes to the fertility of the soil. Animal manures are mostly animal feces. Different types of manures have different properties.

There are also manures which are made from the remains of dead plants.



Fig: Adding manure

- Spraying of insecticides: Insecticides are used to keep the plants away from any types of insects which may harm the crops.



Fig: Spraying

- Harvesting: After all this hardship the crop grows and then the harvesting is done.

So, we can now say, that farming is not only about sowing the seeds and reaping the crop. Different things along with the seeds are also used such as fertilizers, herbicides and pesticides.

What we eat today is very different from what our grandparents used to eat. A few years back more vegetables and fruits were used in the daily diet. Due importance was given to the cereals too. But with the changing times our food habits have also changed. In old times there was less use of pesticides and chemical fertilizers as compared to present times.

Today a lot of fast food and processed food has taken place of vegetables and pulses. This is the main reason for nutritional deficiency amongst us today.

The food habits also vary from place to place. Different regions have different food habits and this has an effect on the crops grown there. Cultures also have effect on the food eaten in a region.

For example:

In north, a lot of dairy products are used in cooking the food, in west part of our country coconut is included in the food. So different people from different places and cultures have different food habits.

We all eat food and need it in order to live and work. But there are people who do not get enough food sometimes. This situation can be either because of natural causes or it can be man-made.

The lack of availability of food is called famine.



Fig: Famine (lack of availability of food)

Sometimes lack of rain causes famine. This situation is called drought. The decrease in supply of water does not let the crops to grow and hence there is shortage of food.

The other reasons can be floods, volcanic eruptions and earthquakes. Sometimes the production of food is less than required.

There can also be shortage of food when the food gets spoiled in a large quantity. This happens when the food is stored improperly. Because of this the food gets wasted.

This causes a lot of diseases and deaths. The diseases caused due to improper or inadequate food are called malnutrition diseases where the word 'malnutrition' means lack of nutrition. Our body can work properly only if we get proper and sufficient food.